involves a state of full awareness of the ultimate oneness of the soul, atman, and Brahman; the Hindu realises the Divine within himself, perceives the Divine in other beings, and accepts that Brahman is in everything, and everything is Brahman.

Without beginning and end is he; in the midst
Of chaos is he, and brings forth all things. Creator
Is he, and sole pervader, of manifold forms.
When a man knows God he is freed from all fetters.

— *Svetashvatara Upanishad*, V.13.2[2]

Despite such ideas being seen by many as Brahminical and elitist, Advaita Vedanta, by conceiving of Oneness in this manner, lays the philosophical groundwork for the fundamental equality of all human beings. In the same section of his *Upadeshasahasri*, Adi Shankara posits precisely this ethical premise of equality; any *bheda* (discrimination) based on class or caste or parentage is, Shankara declared, a mistake, a sign of error and of lack of knowledge. Shankara's liberated individual understands and practises the ethics of non-discrimination, since the high-born and the low are all part of the same Oneness. This was all the more significant in a religion on which the pernicious practice of caste discrimination had begun to cast a blight. The Advaita Vedantist recognised all living beings as essentially one, and therefore as essentially equal.

The fully realised self is *sat-chit-ananda* incarnate, as Shankara himself sings:

'Atma Shatakam' (The Song of the Self):

I am not the mind, nor the intellect, nor the ego, nor the material
of the mind;
I am not the body, nor the changes of the body;
I am not the senses of hearing, taste, smell, or sight,
Nor am I the ether, the earth, the fire, the air;
I am Existence Absolute, Knowledge Absolute, Bliss
Absolute—I am Shiva, I am Shiva. (Shivoham, Shivoham).

I am not the Prâna, nor the five vital airs;
I am not the materials of the body, nor the five sheaths;
Neither am I the organs of action, nor the object of the senses;
I am Existence Absolute, Knowledge Absolute, Bliss Absolute—
I am Shiva, I am Shiva. (Shivoham, Shivoham).